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White House softens parts of Trump’s pitch for Gaza

Proposal to remove all Palestinians draws swift backlash in Arab world

BY CLAIRE PARKER
AND SUSANNAH GEORGE

JERUSALEM — U.S. foes and allies alike condemned on Wednesday President Donald Trump’s proposal that the United States take over Gaza and remove its residents en masse — a suggestion world leaders and analysts said could inflame conflict in the region, alienate long-standing Arab allies and, if implemented, amount to the forced displacement of a civilian population, a crime under international law.

Trump in recent weeks had floated the idea of moving Pales-

tinians out of Gaza and into Egypt, Jordan or other countries while the enclave, which has been devastated by war, was rebuilt. The proposal drew sharp rejections in both Cairo and Amman.

But his comments Tuesday from the White House, alongside Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, took an already controversial and unpopular idea further: Palestinians should leave Gaza, which has been “very unlucky for them,” and move to a

SEE REACTION ON A12

Israeli reactions: The far right exults, but others are fearful. **A12**



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt shows photos of Gaza devastation at a Wednesday news briefing.

MASS DISPLACEMENT WOULD BE TEMPORARY

No U.S. troops or taxes, but still little clarity on vision

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM
AND MATT VISER

The White House on Wednesday tried to soften the most extreme elements of President Donald Trump’s declaration that he wanted to take ownership of Gaza, floating a more limited vision of U.S. involvement in the region.

Press secretary Karoline Leavitt told reporters at the White House news briefing that Palestinians would be displaced temporarily rather than permanently, as Trump had said a day earlier. She said he had made no U.S. troop

commitments despite his vow that the United States would dismantle bombs and clear out the territory. And she said that no U.S. tax dollars would be spent in the years-long reconstruction effort despite Trump’s statement the day before that “the U.S. will take over the Gaza Strip, and we will do a job with it, too. We’ll own it.”

Leavitt’s explanation did little to appease critics, including a wide array of U.S. allies and Pales-

SEE GAZA ON A13

Gazans’ views: Residents say they should decide enclave’s future. **A13**

Beijing digs in, eyeing a ‘grand deal’ for TikTok

China might let app die without trade, tech policy concessions from Trump

BY ELIZABETH DWOSKIN,
NAOMI NIX
AND DREW HARWELL

TikTok’s Chinese owner appears to be slow-rolling negotiations for a sale while waiting for a green light from the Chinese government, even as corporate allies of President Donald Trump race to broker a deal to sell the app to an American bidder, according to three people familiar with the talks who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private business transactions.

But Beijing is increasingly likely to take a hard-line approach, letting TikTok’s U.S. operations die rather than approving a sale as it holds out for a “grand deal” with the Trump administration that includes larger concessions on trade and tech policy, according to one of the people and analysts.

The move comes as tensions between the nations have escalated into a trade war, with Trump drawing on emergency economic powers to impose sweeping tariffs on imports from China this week. Beijing retaliated with its own set of restrictions, including limits on exports of minerals used to make high-tech products and an antitrust investigation of Google.

The tactic is likely to undermine efforts from Trump, who has vowed to “save TikTok” by suspending enforcement of a law forcing a sale or a ban of the app while he negotiates divestment. It would also decimate a service that 170 million users nationwide depend on for entertainment and socializing.

Rui Ma, an investor and ana-

SEE TIKTOK ON A16

After 24 years in the U.S., a Guatemalan father of four fears for his future as he heads to what used to be an uneventful annual check-in with ICE



An immigrant’s fate hinges on one day

Eulogio Hernández Box lit a candle at the altar in his living room and knelt to pray. In the predawn darkness, all was quiet in the small house with white siding. His wife was already working her regular factory shift that started at 5 a.m. His four sons — 16, 15, 10 and 9 — were still asleep.

It was early on Jan. 22. Two days earlier, a new president had taken office promising to deport millions of people who were in the country illegally.

Eulogio was one of them. He had arrived as a teenager in 2001, leaving behind his village in Guatemala. In the years since, he had worked hard and provided for his children.

Now he was 39. After 24 years, his ability to remain in the country would come down to a check-in later that day at an Immigration and

BY JOANNA SLATER
WITH PHOTOGRAPHY
BY REBECCA KIGER
IN DOVER, OHIO

Eulogio Hernández Box, now a target of the Trump administration’s deportation push, ponders what will come as he sits in his kitchen while his son John washes the dishes.

Customs Enforcement office outside Cleveland.

Eulogio dressed carefully: jeans and a belt with a large silvery buckle, a dark green polo shirt from the men’s spiritual retreat he helps lead each year. Around his neck, he wore a St. Benedict crucifix on a black cord.

Before leaving home, he blew out the flame and went to hug his sleeping children. “See you in the afternoon,” he whispered to each of them.

The truth was he might not be coming back.

For an administration determined to ramp up deportations, people like Eulogio were easy targets. They were already subject to deportation orders, but under President Joe Biden, they were not considered priorities for removal because they did not represent a threat to public safety. They number in the hundreds of thousands.

SEE IMMIGRANT ON A8

Order aims to ban trans athletes from female teams

BY HANNAH NATANSON
AND LAURA MECKLER

President Donald Trump signed an executive order Wednesday that aims to ban transgender athletes from competing on girls’ and women’s sports teams by denying federal funds for schools that allow it, delivering on another contentious culture war promise.

The order directs the Education Department to inform

schools that allowing transgender athletes to compete will put them in violation of Title IX, the federal law banning sex discrimination in schools. Under the law, schools that discriminate based on sex are not eligible for federal funding.

It’s the latest salvo in Trump’s attack on transgender rights, another in a series of moves ricocheting through school districts and college campuses across the country.

“From now on, women’s sports

will be only for women,” Trump said Wednesday before a cheering crowd in the East Room of the White House. “The war on women’s sports is over.”

He said the order was part of a “sweeping effort to reclaim our culture and our laws.”

On the first day of his presidency, Trump signed an order declar-

SEE SCHOOLS ON A6

Sally Jenkins: This brutish ban seeks to demonize, not protect. **D1**



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

What happened on Wednesday

The Senate voted to confirm Scott Turner as secretary of the Department of Housing and Urban Development.

Pam Bondi, shown at left being sworn in, created a “Weaponization Working Group” to review instances of “politicized justice,” ended the federal moratorium on the death penalty and paused grant funding for sanctuary cities in her first day as attorney general. **A2**

A federal judge indefinitely blocked Trump’s effort to curb birthright citizenship for the children of undocumented immigrants. **A6**

IN THE NEWS

Flipping the switch Clean-power firms worried about funding are tailoring their pitches to fit the Trump administration’s push for “energy dominance.” **A20**

A clarion call Maryland Gov. Wes Moore (D) implored state leaders to summon courage as they face twin challenges. **B1**

THE NATION
A return-to-office crackdown by the Trump administration has alarmed military families who rely on remote federal jobs to accommodate frequent moves. **A9**

THE WORLD
A special unit of Ukrainian soldiers in Russia’s Kursk region is reaching out to civilians living in the occupied area under their control, hoping to win them over and catch it on film. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
The removal of a loophole in taxes on imports means that orders from Shein and Temu might soon get 30 percent more expensive. **A14**
Whole Foods said Trump’s firing of two NLRB leaders rendered moot the union win at a Philadelphia store. **A15**

THE REGION
A flock of backyard chickens in Montgomery County tested positive for the bird flu. **B1**
A family that lost a mother and daughter in the plane crash near National Airport would have soon moved into a new house, but now it won’t ever be a home. **B1**

SPORTS
The Wizards sent Kyle Kuzma to Milwaukee for Khris Middleton as part of a larger deal ahead of the trade deadline. **D1**
LOCAL LIVING
An empty nest was never much of a garden-er, but she still took on the restoration of a mountaintop meadow.

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